Nonetheless, the government—aware of the stakes—tried (unsuccessfully) to stop the shipment. It subsequently accepted a solution proposed by Dulles.[273] Delhi declared that the thorium nitrate was for commercial purposes in China and that India did not expect any such future shipments to China or other countries in the Soviet orbit. Later, when China and the Soviet Union approached India for more thorium nitrate, Indian officials looked to the US to purchase it instead.[274]

For the rest of 1953 and through 1954, there continued to be debate about the necessity and benefits of aiding India. Under Secretary of State Walter Bedell Smith felt that the relationship with India would survive an aid stoppage.[275] Dulles disagreed, however, noting that aid termination would leave the US no way of ensuring stability in India. Furthermore, along with the general negative impact on the US-India relationship, such a cutoff would have "unfortunate results which would likely take place in connection with discussions of Asian problems, UN debates and resolutions, and India's work as chairman [of] NNRC."[276] In this way, at least, India's international role helped its case.

Like its predecessor, the Eisenhower administration had little to no expectation that aid would lead India to jettison nonalignment and move closer to the US.[277] The purpose of aid to the South Asian countries at the time, as Vice President Richard Nixon put it, was not primarily "a desire to gain credit or to buy friendship, but rather to build up these countries."[278]

In early 1954, NSC 5409—United States Policy toward South Asia—emphasized the stakes involved given "the consolidation of communist control in China" and the setbacks in Indochina. It and supporting documents reinforced various themes: South Asia as "a major battleground in the cold war," China-India competition, the threat posed by India's internal economic and political vulnerability, the adverse impact if India —"potentially … the pivot of the whole area"—were lost. If democratic India did not progress, while communist China did, then South Asians might turn to communism. And China seemed to be delivering faster.[279] Therefore, even though Nehru irked Eisenhower and Dulles, they saw the need to help India. Of the economic aid requested for underdeveloped countries for 1955—even though it paled in comparison to military assistance and aid to allies—the largest request was for India.